

CS N R E H S KAS

Contributor: Rabbi
Moshe D. Gutnick,
Sydney, Australia

Compiled by: Rabbi
Yehudah Altein

Reviewed by: Rabbi
Yosef Y. Shusterman &
Dayan Levi Y. Raskin





**Halochos &
Practical Tips
for Kashering
a Kitchen**



robably one of the most invasive things we do when we are mekarev a family to Yiddishkeit is to kasher their home. We enter the kitchen, take apart the contents of the cupboards, wave

about a blowtorch, and pour boiling water all over the room. The mess is inevitable, and it's a miracle if at least one dish or bowl isn't destroyed along the way.

Despite these incongruities, this is what we must do to bring our baalei batim across the line from being observers to observant. It therefore behooves us to acquire a thorough knowledge of the halochos associated with kashering, not just from issur to heter but from chometz to Pesach as well. In this article we will attempt to give a brief yet thorough overview of these halochos and their applications in today's kitchens.

This article has been written bearing in mind the ikar hadin, in order to assist families accepting the daunting challenge of keeping kosher. Accordingly, in some places we have suggested leniencies and have described them as such. However, as Chassidim and shluchim, we are generally obliged not to look for leniencies in our homes and Botei Chabad but to take a stricter approach. This is especially our custom when it comes to Pesach. As such, please consult a Chassidishe rov competent in this area as to when and if any leniency mentioned here can be applied in your specific situation.

KASHERING INTRODU

We will begin by going through a number of introductory concepts.



NOSAIN TA'AM LIFGAM

If a vessel has not been used for (at least) twenty-four hours, whatever issur is absorbed in the utensil becomes fouled (pogum) and is no longer considered edible, consequently losing its status of issur. This means that, technically, any clean vessel that has not been used for twenty-four hours becomes kosher. However, Chazal decreed that lechatchila all vessels should be treated as if they are presently within twenty-four hours of use.

Within twenty-four hours, a vessel is called ben yomo; after twenty-four hours it is called aino ben yomo.

Bedieved, any foodstuff cooked inadvertently in an aino ben yomo vessel remains kosher. However, lechatchila such vessels must be kashered.

When kashering with *hag'olo* (see below), the utensil being kashered should not have been used for twenty-four hours beforehand. The reason for this is because if it was used within this time, the hot kashering water will absorb the issur and then make the utensil ossur again. The only way to kasher with *hag'olo* is to wait twenty-four hours beforehand, so that the kashering water does not become ossur.

However, when kashering with libun (see below), a twenty-four-hour waiting

period is not required, as the issur is consumed by the fire.

There are several methods by which something can be kashered. We will examine what each method entails:



HAG'OLO

BRINGING A POT OF WATER TO A BOIL AND DIPPING UTENSILS INTO IT.

Similarly, a pot itself can be kashered with *hag'olo* by filling it with water to the top and bringing the water to a boil, ensuring that it spills over the entire rim.

When using *hag'olo* or any kashering method in which water is used (i.e., irui kli rishon and irui kli rishon im even meluban), the utensil must be clean prior to kashering, without any rust or residue, and it must be left for twenty-four hours before being kashered (as stated above).

After kashering, the utensil should be rinsed in cold water. However, if this was not done, the kashering is still effective. After the kashering is complete, the minhag is to re-kasher the pot that was used for kashering. This can be done by simply adding more water to the water already in the pot, thus raising its original level, and then bringing the water to a boil.

CTION ▶▶▶



IRUI KLI RISHON

POURING WATER DIRECTLY FROM A BOILING KETTLE ONTO THE SURFACE BEING KASHERED IN ONE UNBROKEN STREAM.

IRUI KLI RISHON IM EVEN MELUBAN

Heating up half a brick, stones, or metal on the stovetop, and then pouring water directly from a kettle onto both the surface being kashered and the heated materials as they are being passed across that surface. The stones or metal can be moved around using a pair of tongs or pliers.



LIBUN KAL, YAD SOLEDES

FIRE IS USED TO HEAT METAL SO THAT THE OTHER SIDE OF THE METAL IS HOTTER THAN YAD SOLEDES.

In this context, this means a temperature hotter than 176°F/80°C. An easy way to test this is to splash a tiny drop of water on the surface; if it is hot enough, the droplet will boil.

This type of libun can be considered the same as hag'olo. It requires a clean utensil but does not require a waiting period of twenty-four hours before kashering. (This is a unique view of the Alter Rebbe, as understood particularly by the Rebbe Rashab in his guidelines for hag'olo.)

1 See the new print of the Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim, 451:10, fn. 61.



LIBUN KAL, KASH NISRAF

Fire is used to heat metal so that the other side can scorch kash (straw, or its equivalent—paper). This temperature is 459°F/232°C.² This form of libun kal has the additional advantage of being able to kasher surfaces that may be rusted, or joints that may have residue beneath them.

2 See *ibid.*, 451:16, fn. 117.



LIBUN GOMUR

Fire is used to heat an earthenware material (cheres) until it gives off sparks (as granules of the earthenware material combust), or to heat metal until it glows red.³ The accepted temperature for libun gomur is about 900°F/482°C.

There are two further concepts that must be mentioned:

3 *Ibid.*, 451:7.



KEBOL'O KACH POLTO

This means that a substance ejects *issur* in the same way it absorbs it. If a utensil was used to boil food, the way to kasher it is through boiling, i.e., hag'olo. If a utensil was used for dry roasting or broiling, the way to kasher it is through dry roasting or broiling, i.e., a direct fire—libun. If it was used by having hot liquid poured onto it (*irui kli rishon*), it can be kashered with *irui kli rishon*.



THE MATERIAL OF THE UTENSIL

It is important to be aware of the material from which a utensil is made. Certain materials can be kashered with hag'olo, others require libun kal, and some, regardless of how they are used, will always require libun gomur.

With all the above in mind, we can now proceed to kasher our kitchen.

The following tables and notes detail the proper way to kasher a wide variety of kitchen utensils and components. Of course, properly preparing the person or family whose kitchen is being kashered is an important prerequisite that must be done with great care and sensitivity. Relevant tips can be found in the sidebars accompanying this article. As with all halachic matters, it is always important to consult with a competent *rov* who is knowledgeable in the specific subject being addressed.

POTS AND PANS ▶▶▶

USED FOR COOKING

	Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
Metal (such as stainless steel, cast iron, or aluminum)	✓ ⁴			or ✓ ⁵			
Glass	✓ ⁶						
Enamel				✓ ⁷	or ✓ ⁸		
Earthenware							✓ ⁹
With PTFE non-stick coating, such as Teflon	✓ ¹⁰						
With (newer) ceramic non-stick coating	✓ ¹¹						
Handles		✓		or ✓ ¹²			
Lids	✓ ¹³				or ✓ ¹⁴		
Rivets and joints					or ✓ ¹⁵		

⁴ As stated above, this would entail filling the pot to the rim with water and bringing it to a boil, ensuring that water spills over the entire rim. After the boiling water is emptied, the utensil should be rinsed in cold water to prevent the non-kosher kashering water from being re-absorbed.

⁵ If less than twenty-four hours have passed, libun kal can be used for metal pots and pans.

⁶ Libun kal should not be used for glass.

⁷ Poskim disagree how enamelware can be kashered. In my view, kashering with *libun kal, kash nisraf* is a good compromise (see *Hag'olas Keilim*, p. 293).

⁸ See previous note.

⁹ An earthenware pot, such as a crockpot, can only be kashered with *libun gomur*. However, since *libun gomur* could easily destroy the pot, Chazal forbade

kashering earthenware in that manner, because they were concerned that a person would not kasher it properly due to fear of breaking it.

The only solution for a crockpot is what is called returning it to the kiln. It is likely that there is a pottery kiln in your city, or even in one of the schools. The crockpot can be placed in the kiln and be made to go through a full cycle. Since the pot was placed in a kiln, Chazal were not concerned that a proper job would not be done (ibid., 451:9).

¹⁰ See note 17.

¹¹ See note 17.

¹² An alternative method to *irui kli rishon* is to simply turn the pot upside down over the fire until *libun kal, yad soledes* is achieved. Usually the handles will reach *libun kal, yad soledes* as well. If they don't, *irui kli rishon* is still needed on the handles.

¹³ The lid of a pot must be kashered as well. Care must be taken to unscrew any handle that protrudes into the underside of the lid. If it cannot be unscrewed, *libun kal, kash nisraf* must be performed on the inside of the lid. Similarly, care must be taken to thoroughly clean the small steam vents that collect residue, or else to perform *libun kal, kash nisraf* on them.

¹⁴ See previous note.

¹⁵ If the pot has rivets or joints on the inside, the only way to properly clean the rivets is to use *libun kal, kash nisraf*, which ensures that any residue in the joint is consumed. Joints on the outside of the pot are not considered halachically a problem.

¹⁶ How do you know when *libun gomur* is achieved? This is sometimes difficult to ascertain. A stainless steel baking tray must turn

BAKING DISHES



	Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
Without coating						✓ ¹⁶	
With PTFE non-stick coating, such as Teflon (affected by heat)							✓ ¹⁷
With (newer) ceramic non-stick coating (not affected by heat)						✓ ¹⁸	
Aluminum baking trays							✓ ¹⁹
Correlle, Corningware, glass and ceramic baking dishes							✓ ²⁰
Silicon bakeware							✓
Deep fryer	✓ ²¹						
Frying pans without coating						✓ ²²	
Frying pans with PTFE non-stick coating, such as Teflon							✓ ²³
Frying pans with (newer) ceramic non-stick coating						✓ ²⁴	

red lightly. At the point when this takes place, the stainless steel actually discolours, so the family should be warned that this will take place. The simplest way to achieve this is by turning the tray upside down over the stovetop over two full flames (or more if necessary). The tray will usually change color within a few minutes.

A cast iron baking tray will usually not change color. From a practical perspective, turning a cast iron baking tray upside down over the fire for fifteen minutes will kasher the tray.

A handy tool to assist in this process is a temperature gauge used for measuring the temperature of metal. These can be purchased at most metallurgical stores. As stated above, the accepted temperature for libun gomur is about 900 °F/482 °C.

17 If a pan used for baking or frying is coated with Teflon, it cannot be kashered, because

the fear that the fire will ruin the Teflon may prevent a person from doing a proper job. However, some of the newer non-stick surfaces are not affected by heat, and these may be kashered.

18 See previous note.

19 One cannot do *libun gomur* on aluminum baking trays. The trays melt; not a good look when kashering someone's kitchen. Large globules of molten aluminum falling everywhere do not engender confidence in the family whose home is being kashered. However, aluminum clad stainless steel baking or frying pans can be kashered and will not melt.

20 A ceramic dish, however, can be re-kilned (see above, note 9).

21 See following note.

There is a halachic question whether frying pans have the din of a cooking utensil or a baking dish. Usually one fries with oil, and

that is considered cooking. A deep fryer, for example, needs only *hag'olo* (after a very thorough cleaning). However, sometimes the oil in a frying pan dries out, and the remainder of the frying is the equivalent of baking or roasting. As such, the halacha is that a frying pan requires *libun gomur*.

22 Frying pans usually have a buildup of carbonized material on the outside and even on the inside. Provided a proper libun gomur is performed, this does not pose a problem. Be aware, however, that both with a frying pan and with some other baking dishes, this burnt-on fat has not quite completely carbonized and will burst into flames during the kashering process. This will only last a few moments as it, too, is carbonized.

23 See note 17.

24 See note 17.

DISHES ►►►

		Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
Corelle		✓						
Plastic and Bakelite		✓						
Metal		✓						
Wood		✓						
Glass		✓ ²⁵						
China, porcelain, and ceramic								✓ ²⁶
Silicon		✓						
Serving trays (metal, wood, and plastic)			✓					
Single-piece metal cutlery		✓						
Knives, ladles, and carving forks with handles into which the blade or ladle is inserted	Joint					✓ ²⁷		
	Rest of utensil	✓						
Strainers with criss-crossing wire						✓ ²⁸		
Chip holders (used in deep fryers) with criss-crossing wire						✓ ²⁹		
Colander		✓ ³⁰						
Tongs and forks used on barbecues and grills							✓ ³¹	

25 Care must be taken when kashering glass that it should not shatter in the hot water. This can be achieved by warming the utensils under the hot water faucet before dipping them into the boiling water. It is the sudden change in temperature that shatters the glass, and prewarming prevents this from happening.

It is important to note that while *minhag ashkenaz* is to refrain from kashering glass for Pesach, the consensus of poskim is that glass can be kashered

from issur. Corelle is a form of glass. Drinking glassware that has never been washed with water hotter than *yad soledes* can be kashered by soaking them in water for twenty-four hours three times, with the water being changed after each twenty-four hour period. If there is a lot of such glassware, this can be facilitated by using the bathtub, making sure to leave a path to the drain.

26 Dishes made of china, porcelain, and ceramic require *libun gomur*. As explained in note 9, Chazal ruled out this

method of kashering such materials, and the halachically acceptable solution is to kasher them via re-kilning.

It is important to note that there is a large chance that some of the china might crack during re-kilning. Therefore, when dealing with expensive china, Reb Moshe Feinstein made an allowance for people beginning to keep kosher. The china can be kashered by first leaving them unused for twelve months, followed by kashering each utensil in boiling water three times.

This is a combination of two leniencies, one argued by the Chacham Tzvi who posited that the law of aging for twelve months—which permits vessels in a winery—applies to other issurim as well, and a second based on the opinion of Baal Ha'itur who holds that china can be kashered by doing hag'olo three times. The general practice is to allow this leniency for people beginning to keep

kosher for the first time.

27 It should be noted that many modern utensils have a plastic handle that is perfectly fused to the blade. Food simply cannot get into the joint. Such a joint does not require libun.

28 The reason for this is because it is assumed that residue gets stuck between the wires (see above that *libun kal, kash nisraf* has the ability to remove

residue).

29 The fryer itself, if clean, requires only *hag'olo* (see note 22).

30 Since the colander has holes (as opposed to criss-crossing wire), there is no concern for stuck residue, and *hag'olo* is sufficient.

31 The reason for this is because they are used in direct contact with meat that is in direct contact with the flame.

STOVE TOPS INCLUDING GRATES

	Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
Metal and enamel		✓ ³²			or ✓ ³³		
Glass		✓ ³⁴					
Ceramic				✓ ³⁵	or ✓ ³⁶		

32 There are poskim who argue that a stovetop need only be cleaned and it can immediately be used for kosher cooking. The rationale for this is based on the halachic principle that issur can only be transferred via moisture. A dry pot on a dry stovetop, by contrast, does not allow for any transfer of issur. According to the Mechaber, we follow the majority of use when it comes to kashering. Since almost all of the time there is no transfer of issur to the stovetop, the occasional spill is deemed halachically insignificant. Even if a subsequent spill of kosher food were to take place, the heat of the stove may have already kashered it from the previous spill, and furthermore, more than twenty-four hours has anyways elapsed since the previous non-kosher spill. Notwithstanding all the above, the common practice is to kasher stovetops. However, since the only thing we are concerned about is the liquid that has

spilled over onto the stovetop, all that is required (according to most poskim) is *irui kli rishon*, pouring water from a kettle onto the surface.

Of course, *libun kal, yad soledes* would also suffice. (Note that this is not the case for Pesach—see sidebar.) The simplest way to achieve this is by placing a blech over the entire stovetop and turning on the flames. Within five to ten minutes, the required heat is achieved.

This works for metal and enamel stovetops. However, glass stovetops may crack, so they are best kashered by pouring boiling water on them. The heat should first be turned on high for five minutes.

It is also important to remember that as explained above, once twenty-four hours has elapsed since the non-kosher usage, no subsequent kosher usage will be affected. There is a rabbinic requirement to kasher the stovetop

anyway, which we do to the best of our ability. Even if we inadvertently err, there is no consequence as far as the subsequent food cooked on it is concerned. This halachic reality will sometimes affect the way we pasken. (Here as well, this is not the case for Pesach.)

33 See previous note.

34 See note 32.

35 Ceramic stovetops are more problematic, as ceramic normally requires libun gomur. However, since kashering a stovetop is unnecessary according to some poskim (as explained in note 32), one can rely on libun kal, yad soledes. Kashering though libun kal, kash nisraf would be preferable. Since the stovetop is designed to withstand such heat, the normal rule preventing the use of libun for ceramic does not apply.

36 See previous note.

OVENS

CONVENTIONAL AND CONVECTION

		Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
Top and sides	If flame or electric coil is visible from inside the oven					✓ ³⁷		
	If flame or electric coil is not visible from inside the oven					✓ ³⁸		
Floor						✓ ³⁹	Or ✓ ⁴⁰	
Racks	If food was not placed directly upon them					✓ ⁴¹	Or ✓ ⁴²	
	If food was placed directly upon them						✓ ⁴³	
Stone of a pizza oven with a stone or brick floor							✓ ⁴⁴	

37 The classic oven in the times of Chazal was made of earthenware. As such, the only way it could be kashered was with libun gomur. Similarly, a spit was usually used for roasting. The meat would be in direct contact with the spit (without the medium of water), and as such, the spit required libun gomur (just like baking dishes—see above).

However, our ovens are very different. Most household ovens become filled with steam and vapors which facilitate the transfer of issur. This is a critically important feature that is often overlooked, which then creates a misunderstanding as to how our ovens can be kashered. An oven does not become ossur through direct contact of meat being roasted or broiled in it like the spit of old. It is only the steam—vaporized liquid—that transfers the issur. Therefore, it theoretically only requires hag'olo.

Furthermore, our ovens are formed out of either metal or enamel, not earthenware. Metal can certainly be kashered, and as stated above (note 7), it is acceptable to treat enamelware as metal and perform libun kal, kash nisraf. Therefore, all that is required to kasher a household oven is

libun kal, kash nisraf. This is achieved by turning on the oven to the highest setting for one hour.

38 Most ovens in the United States are designed so that the flame or electric coil is not visible from inside the oven. The normative view is that libun kal only works when the fire or heat source is located inside the oven, and it thus follows that turning on the oven to kasher it would not work if the flame is not visible. In such a case, the oven should be turned on to the highest setting for an hour, and then, at the end of the hour, all the surfaces should be gone over lightly with a blowtorch. It should be noted that sometimes it is possible to remove the back plate or bottom plate and expose the flame or coil, and sometimes the flame or coil is visible behind a grille.

According to my view, in cases of necessity one can rely on the opinions that libun kal, kash nisraf is sufficient for our ovens even if the flame is not visible.

Some convection ovens are designed with a fan and heating coil located behind the backplate of the oven. If possible, this backplate should be removed and the area behind it along with the fan should

be cleaned. If this is not possible, one can rely that the libun kal, kash nisraf will sufficiently consume that residue.

All the opinions of which I am aware consider a self-cleaning oven cycle as proper kashering. Of course, the racks, which generally cannot withstand the self-cleaning cycle, require separate kashering.

39 It is quite common for food to spill onto the floor of the oven and onto the racks, even if one only uses oven pans. Therefore, some opinions hold that the racks and the floor of the oven require libun gomur. In my view, when necessary one can rely on the more lenient view even for the racks (as long as food was not placed directly upon them).

40 See previous note.

41 See note 39.

42 See note 39.

43 Some ovens are designed in such a way that food is placed directly upon the racks. These racks share the din of a spit and require libun gomur.

44 The stone of a pizza oven with a stone or brick floor require libun gomur. This can be achieved by turning the stone (which is usually removable) upside down over the fire for an hour.

SINKS

	Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
Metal		✓ ⁴⁶	or ✓ ⁴⁷	or ✓ ⁴⁸			
Porcelain							✓ ⁴⁹
Faucets and handles		✓	or ✓				

45 It is important to make sure that the sink is clean, especially at the joint of the drain. Pouring bleach around and into the drain and leaving it there for fifteen minutes will dissolve any long-term buildup of residue.

46 Sinks primarily become ossur through irui kli rishon. Therefore, the method of kashering that must be performed is the equivalent—pouring boiling water over the entire surface. However, since solid hot foods are sometimes placed into the sink, it is better to kasher it using irui kli

rishon im even meluban. This should be done after waiting twenty-four hours (as stated above). Libun kal, yad soledes performed with a blowtorch is simpler and just as effective halachically.

47 See previous note.

48 See note 46.

49 Primarily in the United States and Canada (but not so much in Australia and Europe) there is a further problem associated with the kashering of sinks—the fact that sinks are commonly made of porcelain. Porcelain is a kli cheres

and technically cannot be kashered. The common practice is to at least kasher it three times (following the opinion of Baal Ha'itur—see note 26), and to use a washing-up bowl in the sink. If your balabos will be unable to cope with using a washing-up bowl and this might impact his or her willingness to kasher the sink, there are grounds to allow it to be used as is after it is kashered three times.

COUNTER TOPS

		Hag'olo	Irui kli rishon	Irui kli rishon im even meluban	Libun kal, yad soledes	Libun kal, kash nisraf	Libun gomur	Cannot be kashered
All materials except for porcelain	If hot food was not placed directly upon it		✓ ⁵⁰					
	If hot food was placed directly upon it			✓ ⁵¹				
Porcelain								✓ ⁵²

50 If hot food was placed directly upon the countertop, it requires irui kli rishon im even meluban. However, in most kitchens this does not take place, and at most hot

liquids spill onto the countertop. Irui kli rishon is therefore sufficient.

51 See previous note.

52 See above note 49. The same principles

outlined there apply to a porcelain-tiled countertop, but there is more room for the leniency mentioned there to suffice with kashering three times.

PROBLEMATIC ITEMS



DISHWASHERS

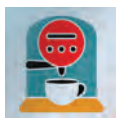
DISHWASHERS WITH METAL WALLS AND PLASTIC RACKS CAN BE KASHERED AS FOLLOWS:

1. **First**, the dishwasher should be cleaned thoroughly, taking special care to clean the drain area and the crevices behind the seals. It should then be run through a full cycle at the hottest setting with detergent, leaving the racks in the dishwasher.
2. **Next**, the dishwasher should be left unused for twenty-four hours.
3. **Finally**, the dishwasher with the racks should be put through the hottest cycle again, this time without detergent.
4. **The dishwasher is kosher at this point.** However, if possible the following should be done as well. When putting the dishwasher through the hottest cycle for a second time (as stated in Step 3), at the hottest point in the cycle, a half brick or piece of metal that has been heated up on the stovetop should be placed inside the dishwasher on a piece of aluminium foil (to avoid melting the rack). This lifts the kashering temperature by another couple of degrees.



GEORGE FOREMANS, WAFFLE MAKERS, TOASTERS

George Foremans, waffle makers, and toasters all require *libun gomur*. Since doing this would damage them, they cannot be kashered. However, one has to establish exactly what type of non-kosher food was used in them. Sometimes, even people who don't keep a kosher home use only kosher meat. Gathering the relevant information may allow a Rov competent in this area to advise you. Similarly, it is possible that the bread used by the family was kosher, so it is worthwhile to ask them this question before throwing out the toaster.



COFFEE MAKERS

Traditional coffee makers with drip units and glass jugs have at most been washed in the sink or a dishwasher. All that is necessary to kasher them is to do *hag'olo* on these parts. The jugs also require *tevila*.

A Keurig or Nespresso does not need to be kashered, unless it was used for non-kosher soups. Any parts that are removable and were washed in the sink or a dishwasher should be kashered with *hag'olo*, and, if made of glass or metal, require *tevila*. Of course, if the family will be observing *cholov yisroel*, the container used for heating and frothing the milk



must be kashered as well.

It is important to make the following observation. While there are those who keep *cholov yisroel* but are not concerned with non-*cholov-yisroel* keilim—and on that basis they have no concerns with buying *pareve* or soy coffee at Starbucks or similar stores—the universal Chabad practice, as well as the practice throughout the *chassidishe* world, is to kasher keilim from *cholov akum* exactly as required by *Shuchan Aruch* without any leniencies. Therefore, we are obliged to be particularly vigilant when buying coffee in any location to ensure that issues of non-*cholov-yisroel* keilim are taken care of.

There is a famous responsum of the *Noda B'Yehuda*¹ where he was asked about drinking coffee in coffee houses. He replied that there are many problems associated with drinking in such establishments (and from my experience, the problems have not changed!) and he therefore advises that one should not rely on leniencies or rulings of *bedieved*, as one can make kosher coffee at home (or at the office). He concludes that the only time it is valid to look for a leniency is when traveling and

there is no other alternative, as that is a case of *bedieved*. In today's context, this would be when one is traveling on the road or in a plane. A rov should be consulted for further advice on this matter.

ELECTRIC GRILLS WITH REMOVABLE PLATES, TRAYS, OR RACKS

The plates, trays, or racks require *libun gomur*. In most cases this will ruin the material and they therefore cannot be kashered. In the case of a new grill or a grill that can be kashered, the parts that come in contact with food require *tevila* as well.



TOASTER OVENS, CONVECTION TOASTER OVENS

These ovens have the same *din* as a regular oven. The trays and racks require *libun gomur* if food is placed on them directly. This will usually ruin them, so new parts must be acquired. All

¹ Mahadura Kama, Yoreh Dei'ah, 36.



parts that come in contact with food require tevila as well.

MICROWAVES

A microwave is a complicated appliance, because the heat is not externally generated, but is created from within the food itself. If something non-kosher was warmed up in a microwave, the issur is transferred to subsequent food items (not via heat, but) via the steam. Therefore, the accepted way to kasher a microwave is as follows:

Clean the microwave thoroughly, especially in the corners and at the joints. Do not use it for twenty-four hours. Pour boiling water from a kettle into a microwave-proof utensil and put the utensil into the microwave. Turn the microwave on high until the microwave fills with steam, and then wipe off the moisture. The glass turnstile should also be kashered with hag'olo.

CONVECTION MICROWAVE OVENS

If the heating element is visible, all that is required is for the oven to be turned on to the highest convection temperature for an hour. If the element is not visible, in addition to turning it on to the

highest temperature for an hour, the process used for kashering a regular microwave should be performed as well.

RICE COOKER

Rice is generically kosher. The only way a rice cooker can become treif is either by being washed up together with non-kosher dishes or if it is not used in the normal fashion. Either way, the rice cooker can be kashered with hag'olo.



MIXERS, ELECTRIC KNIVES, IMMERSION BLENDERS, AND SIMILAR APPLIANCES

The handles or bases of these items must be thoroughly cleaned but do not need to be kashered. All the other parts, such as the blades, paddles, and the like, require both kashering through hag'olo and tevila. Sometimes the parts contain joints and crevices; if they cannot be cleaned, these areas require libun kal, kash nisraf (as mentioned in the main body of the article). If this is not possible, the parts must be replaced.

KASHERING FOR PESACH

In the main article we pretty much covered all the details associated with the kashering of a kitchen. Another topic is the kashering of a kitchen for Pesach. The information in the main article applies to Pesach as well, except for the following exceptions (some of which are *mai'ikar hadin*, others of which are chumros):

1. The grates of a stovetop require *libun gomur* (this is a chumra of the Alter Rebbe⁴).
2. Frying pans only require *libun kal*, *yad soledes*, or *hag'olo*.
3. Porcelain sinks, after being kashered three times, *must* have inserts.
4. Some are machmir not to kasher an enamel oven except with *libun gomur*. I would recommend this chumra at least for the shluchim themselves.
5. I heard from my father-in-law Rabbi Zelig Sharfstein that Reb Zalmen Shimon allowed kashering of plastic for Pesach (in contrast to Reb Moshe Feinstein who did not allow it).
6. We do not kasher Formica countertops; they should be covered. Marble and granite countertops can be kashered with *hag'olo*.
7. There is a machlokes between modern-day poskim whether or not caesarstone can be kashered for Pesach. Caesarstone is ground stone held together with resin. Those who are maikil say it is nothing more than a plastic which can be kashered. The machmirim say that since it contains ground stone, it has the din of cheres and cannot be kashered. I personally am machmir.
8. Ashkenazim hold that glass cannot be kashered for Pesach, because lechatchila it is considered akin to cheres. Since we can assume that almost all glassware was put into a (hot) dishwasher, even drinking glasses should not be used. However, if one has glassware that was never washed with water hotter than *yad soledes* and never contained chometz for more than twenty-four consecutive hours, the minhag is that they can be kashered in the manner described in note 25. In situations of need, a rov should be consulted, as there are grounds to be more flexible.
9. Kashering with boiling water should be completed before the *zman issur achilas chometz*. However, kashering with libun can be performed even after this time.
10. I am sure that the majority of you out there follow this, but *ain mezarzin ela limzurozin*. Kashering for Pesach is difficult and dangerous. Do not let your wife or young children do it. Take proper precautions with the hot water and especially with the blowtorch. Do it when it is convenient for your wife, not when it is convenient for you. Do not allow your wife to become a slave to your chumros—Pesach is the festival of freedom!

⁴ See Alter Rebbe's Shulchan Aruch, *Orach Chaim*, 451:24.

TEVILAS KEILIM ▶▶▶

An important part of the kashering process is toivel the keilim. It is important to note that the only keilim that require tevila min hadin are metal and glass (which includes Corelle and Corningware). China, wood, and plastic do not require tevila, although many have the custom of toiveling china without a brocho. Some toivel plastic as well.

While min hatorah only metal requires tevila, Chazal required glass to be toiveled as well. The reason is because glass can be melted and repaired like metal. By contrast, plastic melts and burns, and therefore it does not require tevila. While in previous ages china may have actually been made with a glass coating, modern-day china contains no glass coating whatsoever. It cannot be melted and cannot be repaired with heat. The shine cannot be construed to be a layer of glass. Therefore, mai'ikar hadin it does not require tevila.

The above is a very important principle to be aware of. Firstly, it makes the process of kashering a kitchen easier. Secondly, you can sometimes be confronted by a situation where someone has a kosher home but you know that he has not toiveled his dishes. While failure to toivel does not render the food non-kosher, it is questionable whether one can drink water from a glass in such a home. But a hot cup of tea in a china cup would pose no problem whatsoever!

Of course, electric keilim pose a unique set of problems, as electricity and water do not

go together. The most lenient view is that of the Chelkas Yaakov. He is of the opinion² that since electrical appliances are plugged into the wall, they are not mekabel tum'ah and therefore do not need to be toiveled. However, even he argues³ that this would only apply, say, to a George Foreman or toaster, because it has no other use other than when it is plugged in. An urn or kettle, by contrast, can be used to hold water even when it is not plugged in, so this heter will not apply.

Many poskim disagree with this "plug-in" heter. Instead they suggest that if a keili cannot be toiveled, it should be given as an absolute gift to a gentile and then borrowed back for use by the Jew. This circumvents the tevila requirement, because keilim owned by a gentile do not require tevila. While this may appear to be a case of legal fiction, when combined with the view of the Chelkas Yaakov, there is a sound heter to avoid tevila. However, as stated, the Chelkas Yaakov does not apply his heter to urns and similar utensils.

It is, however, possible to toivel many electrical appliances in the following manner. The key is to ensure that the item is completely dry before attempting to use it. Once the item has been toiveled (and all it needs is a single dip!), the water should be shaken off of it and it should be left to dry.

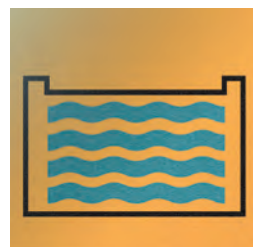
A George Foreman can

be toiveled in the mikvah and then allowed to dry for several days in a warm, dry area. If one is in more of a hurry to use the appliance, a hair dryer can be used to dry it faster. If, after drying, the appliance blows a fuse when it is plugged in, it is a sign that it must be left to dry for longer. Similarly, devices that do not have the "plug-in" heter, such as a kettle, urn, or electric frying pan, can be toiveled in the same way. The longer the keili is left to dry, the better the chance of avoiding damage, as long as the water is shaken off immediately after the tevila.

A toaster has a more delicate electrical structure and the water will likely cause permanent damage. Similarly, if the part requiring tevila has an LED or LCD screen, it will likely be ruined by the water. In such cases, the "plug in" heter together with giving the item as a gift to a goy is the only way to go about it.

Another method is to completely dismantle the utensil and then rebuild it. Since the keili was built by a Jew, the tevila requirement does not apply. However, this is a complicated solution, because taking it apart will not always remove the halachic keili status from the item. A rov should be consulted if this method is being used.

Of course, a base that does not come in contact with food—for example, the base of a blender—does not require tevila.



² Yoreh Dei'ah 41.

³ Ibid. 43.

IN THE LEAD UP TO KASHERING

Of course, it is a fruitless exercise to kasher a home before the family is properly keeping kosher. It is therefore important to first guide the family to a position of proper kashrus observance, and only then to kasher their kitchen.

This means that the family must be taught how to keep kosher. The first step is to make sure the food they buy is kosher. They need to be taught where kosher meat can be purchased, and in the United States and Canada they need to learn which symbols to look for and get used to only buying those products.

In the United Kingdom and the rest of Europe, as well as in Australia and New Zealand, they need to be given a current kosher guide and taught how to use it. In the United Kingdom and Australia there are websites (such as www.ka.org.au) and kosher apps that can be used. It may take some time for a family to get used to using these lists or apps, and it is the shliach's job to carefully guide them through it.

While they are getting used to getting the right ingredients, they also need to practice keeping meat and milk separate. They need to be taught that under no circumstances can meat ingredients be mixed with milk. No more pepperoni on the pizza, and no more cheese on the bolognese. They will need to learn to keep separate utensils, and that the dishwasher can be used for either meat or milk, but not for both.

Some families will be ready to do this immediately, but others will want to take their time to make their way into the routine. Sometimes this means buying a new set of dishes and pots and designating them separately as milk and meat, even before everything is fully kashered. This can become a bit complicated. Is there a value in having a new set of milk or meat utensils before the entire kitchen is kashered? Actually, the answer is yes, and you may not even have to re-kasher the new set when you kasher the kitchen. However, this is a complex issue, so you will need to be in contact with your local Rov who, depending on the particular circumstances, will guide you through the pros and cons of what should be done and when.

Once the family is properly keeping kosher, they will be ready for you to kasher their kitchen.

PREPARING THE FAMILY FOR THE KASHERING PROCEDURE

The better you prepare the family for the kashering process, the easier your job will be. It is worthwhile to visit the home and go through all the utensils, showing them what can be kashered and what cannot and needs to be purchased anew. You will also be able to assess whether you will need help and make a guesstimate how long the kashering will take based on

the amount of utensils that need kashering.

Additionally, you don't want to arrive on "kashering day" and find out that you will need to spend time cleaning, so during this advance visit, you can point out to them which items will need special cleaning. Ovens and baking utensils will often need an overnight dose of oven cleaner. If a lot of kashering will be done with boiling water on countertops and the like, it is a good idea to ask them to have lots of towels handy.

You also need to warn them in advance which items they must refrain from using for the twenty-four hours before kashering. Depending on your relationship with the family, it's probably not a bad idea to invite them to your house for dinner on the night when their utensils cannot be used.

SAFETY AND PRACTICALITY WHILE KASHERING

- Kashering involves lots of hot water, heat, and fire. It is therefore essential to take appropriate safety measures.
- Make sure that your children and all children are nowhere near the kashering area.
- If you will be using hot water, be aware of the locations of the

electrical outlets. Water and electricity do not go together. Wipe up water spills as soon as they happen.

- If possible, use heat-resistant gloves when using hot water.
- Wear comfortable, well-fitted clothing.
- If possible, use rubber-soled, slip-resistant shoes.
- When using a blowtorch, make sure you know in advance where all combustible material is and keep such material far away.
- Know where the smoke detector is and be prepared to temporarily disable it if it goes off.
- Preferably, bring a small portable fire extinguisher graded for electrical and oil fires.
- Take your time, and do everything carefully.

When kashering countertops, try to place towels in areas that will catch the water, for example, under the countertop (between it and the top of the cupboard doors). This will hopefully prevent water from flowing into the cupboards. Wipe up spills as soon as they occur, and do not allow them to accumulate.

I cannot overemphasize the care that must be taken

FINDING THE RIGHT BLOWTORCH



A blowtorch is one of the most convenient tools used for kashering, but it is also potentially the most destructive. As there are quite a few on the market, it is critical to ensure that you have the right one. The oxy-acetylene torch is common in the building industry but is simply not suitable for kashering. Experience has shown that while it heats metal very quickly, it is too hot and can actually cut through the utensil (been there, done that...). The best gas to use is butane gas or LPG (the gas used in barbeque cylinders).

It is also a good idea to obtain a special head made so that the flame is larger (something like three inches in diameter). Less than a minute to libun kal, libun gomur in minutes, house gone in... we won't go there. For commercial applications, the larger head is essential, though you may want to use a smaller head in private homes.

with the blowtorch. As mentioned above, it may even be a good idea to purchase a small portable fire extinguisher to have handy in case of an emergency. A small fire can be put out in moments; if it is not put out, in those same moments it can spread very quickly.

It is not always possible to do the following, but this may avoid a lot of the hassle for the family. If you have a Chabad House with a kitchen, you can pick up their utensils and kasher them at the Chabad House. That way, all the family is "exposed" to is the kashering of the fixed items such as the stove and countertop. You will feel less self-conscious, and usually the Chabad House kitchen will be larger and make the kashering easier. You will anyways need to take their utensils from their house for the purpose of tevila (unless they will be doing the toiveling).

FIRST AID

If someone gets burned, *chas veshalom*, with either hot water or fire, the following guidelines should be followed.

1. STOP THE BURNING PROCESS.

- Consider your own safety first, and stop the source of the burn.
- If you are on fire, stop, drop, and roll along the ground to smother the fire.
- If it's an electrical burn, turn off the power if possible using something dry and non-conductive like a wooden broom handle.
- If it's a chemical burn, remove the burning agent and irrigate with water.

2. RUN COLD WATER.

- Place the burn under running cold water for twenty minutes. Yes, twenty minutes. Not two

minutes, not five minutes, but a full twenty minutes. It does feel like a long time, but it will make a difference to the recovery and treatment of the burn.

- Remove all jewelry, watches, and clothing (if they are not stuck to the burn) once cooling has commenced. If the items have melted and are stuck to the wound, do not attempt to remove them. Seek immediate medical attention.
- Do not use ice, butter, toothpaste, creams, or ointments. These substances can make things worse.

3. SEEK MEDICAL ATTENTION.

- Seek medical attention for all children's burns by calling an ambulance or going to the hospital.
- For adults, seek medical attention if the burn is larger than a U.S. silver half dollar, if it is on the face, hands, or groin area, or if the burn is white in color (which means that it has penetrated deeply).
- If in doubt, do not hesitate—call an ambulance. 📞

Rabbi Moshe D. Gutnick, senior dayan of the Sydney Beth Din and rabbinic administrator of the Kashrut Authority of Australia and NZ, went on shlichus to Sydney, Australia with his wife Esty and newborn daughter in Elul 5742. His shlichus was uniquely directed by the Rebbe to be in kashrus and beis din matters. He can be contacted for kashrus matters at rabbig@ka.org.au and for beis din matters at rabbigutnick@bethdin.org.au.

Article compiled by Rabbi Yehudah Altein